Omen Misty Garden Level Design

Two Connected Worlds

The garden theme is divided into a Surface World and an Inner World. Their maps should be similar in size, but their furnishings and layouts do not need to match. An old television connects the two worlds. Players interact with it to travel between them. The level progresses from the Surface World to the Inner World.

Visual and audio differences can include viewing distance, material colors, how confined the spaces feel, blurred vision, and musical style. Combat in the Inner World becomes more intense: enemies are stronger, groups contain more enemies, and encounters move at a faster pace. Some hidden reward locations from the Surface World can become traps.

Surface World Flow

Enter the level → explore the map → encounter enemies → reach the final room, fight the mini-boss, and interact with the television.

Inner World Flow

Enter the level → explore the map → encounter enemies → discover that the original boss room is locked and receive a puzzle objective → solve the puzzle → enter the final room, fight the boss, and interact with the television to finish the level.

Puzzles could also appear in the Surface World, serving different purposes.

Possible Puzzle Directions

1. Change the player's viewpoint so that parts of the scenery align to form a specific shape.

2. Place three mechanisms throughout the level. Players receive three objects outside the boss room and must place each object at the correct mechanism.

3. Ask players to find a key, revealing the clue to its location outside the boss room.

Possible Garden Elements

Architecture

1. Pavilion (ting): A small, open-sided structure for resting and enjoying the view. Options include hexagonal, square, and double-eaved pavilions.

2. Terrace (tai): An elevated structure for distant views, often placed on a hill or beside water.

3. Tower (lou): A building of two or more stories, used for viewing the garden and storing books. The source gives Yuanxiang Hall Tower in the Humble Administrator's Garden as an example.

4. Belvedere (ge): Similar to a tower, but more refined and elegant, used for viewing or displaying objects.

5. Open study (xuan): An open room beside water or a scenic view, used for reading, writing, and contemplation.

6. Waterside pavilion (xie): A small structure beside or above water, often used for enjoying the breeze and drinking.

7. Boat pavilion (fang): A boat-shaped building, such as a stone boat, evoking the refined pleasure of being on the water.

8. Covered walkway (lang): A long passage connecting spaces. Curved, angled, and encircling walkways create changing views as visitors move.

9. Main hall (tang): The garden's grand central hall, used for receiving guests or hosting banquets.

10. Guest house (guan): A larger residential or reception space, such as the Hall for Listening to Rain.

11. Bridge: Stone bridges, arch bridges, zigzag bridges, and stepping-stone crossings that complement the water features.

Rocks and Terrain

1. Rockery: Taihu stones or yellow stones stacked to evoke natural mountains, with a main peak, caves, ravines, and mountain paths.

2. Rock arrangements: Smaller compositions that emphasize stone textures and the movement of water.

3. Caves: Openings within artificial mountains that suggest a hidden world and invite exploration.

4. Slopes and terraces: Changes in elevation that create spatial depth.

Water Features

1. Ponds: Suzhou gardens commonly use artificial ponds with irregular outlines and stone banks.

2. Streams: Connections between different water levels that bring movement to the garden.

3. Open water: Larger gardens may include broad expanses of water, such as the central pond in the Humble Administrator's Garden.

4. Waterfalls and gullies: Often incorporated into rockeries and rock arrangements.

5. Ripples and reflections: Suzhou gardens place particular emphasis on creating a picture within the water.

Planting

1. Pine, bamboo, and plum: Symbols of steadfastness and integrity, known as the Three Friends of Winter.

2. Willow and lotus: Common waterside plants that suggest gentleness and purity.

3. Peach, apricot, and osmanthus: Plants associated with spring, fragrance, and refinement.

4. Flowers and greenery: Seasonal changes are important, with examples including spring plum blossom, summer lotus, autumn chrysanthemum, and winter bamboo.

5. Bamboo groves and paths: Planting that reinforces a quiet, secluded atmosphere.

Scenic Composition and Supporting Elements

1. Decorative lattice windows: Openwork patterns frame borrowed views of the scenery beyond.

2. Screen walls: Walls at an entrance that interrupt sightlines and create a spatial turn.

3. Whitewashed walls and dark roof tiles: The garden's base palette, setting off its flowers and trees.

4. Door openings: Moon gates, fan-shaped openings, and vase-shaped openings used to frame views.

5. Plaques and paired inscriptions: Text that establishes a scene's theme and adds cultural character.

6. Paving: Pebble mosaics and gray-brick surfaces that enrich the view underfoot.

7. Lanterns, railings, and carvings: Fine decorative details.